

and solving a problem is a good rule of thumb for building your own project. Noting down the problems that others may face will create a demand for it. The size of the market for your project can be estimated only through trial and error. For new and individual contributors who do not have much funding, social media, blogs, posts and talks at conferences help reaching out to users to a large extent. These platforms can generate a lot of traffic for your open source project.

Funding plays an important role in almost all business models. The Mozilla Foundation relies on voluntary donations to fund its projects. MariaDB follows the business model of delayed open sourcing. Many of IBM's open source projects follow the open core business model, i.e., the core of the project is open sourced while the surrounding add-ons are closed source and proprietary. Red Hat doesn't sell code; instead, it sells professional services like support, tooling, and technical assistance around a project. These examples of business models can be adopted to build a project, open source it, and monetise it.

"Do a maintainer's job even if you are not a maintainer."

Work for a company that builds projects with an open source business model: Being a part of a community of contributors and maintainers, engaging in talks and participating in meetings will help you to contribute to a project. You can follow the guidelines for how the first contribution can be made, which doesn't necessarily have to be code. Looking at a big code base may seem intimidating but starting small is the key here. Look for a problem and fix it. This will help you understand the contribution flow, code base, set up of the project, etc.

Non-code contributions are also valuable. People great at writing can contribute by documenting or writing for social media. Those who excel at designing, can design a convention, a

Tips for contributors

- With time, the quality and quantity of contributions will get better. Be involved in a project for a long time since more areas for contribution can be found. Jumping in and contributing will make people notice and recognise you.
- Open source projects lack project managers; hence becoming one will help your career.
- Be a maintainer, doing things that an engineer is expected to do like reviewing, designing, documenting, and helping others contribute.
- The key to good contribution is 'paying it forward', which means helping newcomers by sharing experiences and wisdom, and making sure they don't commit mistakes.

colour scheme, or also work on creating a better user interface. Newcomers have a high probability of discovering bugs when compared to senior engineers. They can test, identify, and report their user experience, thus improving the project. Mentoring is another area. A lot of open source programs connect mentors and mentees, and help the latter make important contributions. Another option is being an organiser or a community manager, which means taking up the role of a project manager and ensuring that features are delivered exactly as intended, the roadmap is followed and the contributors are taken care of. Most open source projects lack proper management, since engineers don't like doing that job.

There are a lot of internship programs that can help you make money, like Google Summer of Code (GSoC) and Linux Foundation mentorship (here, mentees are paid a stipend and can work full- or part-time based on their need). You can get a full-time role with a company you are interning with if you develop your skills well. For instance, if you are working on a project at Red Hat, there are chances of your getting hired full-time because you are already known there.

As Travis Oliphant, creator of NumPy, SciPy and Anaconda, says, "Build an open source project, get people to contribute to it, and hire from them." This is how I got my full-time job too.

Get sponsored to work in open

source: As an individual, if you are working for a project that is built by a company, you can ask for funding. It is important to note that only if your contribution is significant will the organisation be happy to sponsor you. However, if you have built your own project that has a significant user base, you could ask for funding from users.

As an organisation, you can raise money through platforms like Open Collective, Patreon and GitHub Sponsors, where people donate to your project. Open source grants like Linux Foundation and Mozilla Foundation also provide funds to support projects. GitHub has given 15 Indian contributors grants for their projects.

I built an open source project in a span of three months. This project went on to get featured on Product Hunt and JS Weekly and also got the #1 trending slot on GitHub. This project put me on a path to a career in open source.  END

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